

# The Acropolis

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The temples on the Acropolis, a sacred rocky hill dedicated to Athena on the outskirts of Athens, represent the pinnacle of Greek architectural achievement. The hill had been inhabited as far back as the fifth millennium BCE, but Pericles (c.495–429 BCE) ordered and coordinated the construction of the site's most important buildings, including the Parthenon, the Propylaea, the Erechtheion and the Temple of Athena Nike.

The sculptor Phidias (480–430 BCE) planned the layout for visual drama and spatial harmony, and most of the architecture was built in the Doric order, with slender columns and lavishly decorated friezes. A grand stairway leads to the marble columns of the Propylaea, a road for carts and sacrificial beasts, marking the entrance to the holiest area of the Acropolis. Behind the Propylaea stood a 9-metre (30-ft) bronze statue of Athena Promachos, while the elegant marble Temple of Erechtheion (c.420–393 BCE), built on a sloping site, has an entrance lined with six monumental caryatids (columns in the form of female figures), and two porches.

